Social justice through stories

Teacher lesson plan | Read, discuss, respond and connect

Purpose and learning goals

Use books selected by the teacher, with optional input from Laura, to explore rights, belonging and voice. Students identify a book's key message, support an interpretation with words or pictures, explain why the learning matters, and connect ideas across books. They communicate through meaningful illustration and words, orally or with support.

Materials and preparation

Use the approved eight-page grayscale student booklet and six station signs, selected books, pencils and drawing tools. Offer extra copies of the continuation page (page 8), accessible text or audio where available, and a shared place to record evidence. Preview every book for age suitability, accuracy and respectful representation. Select relevant pages rather than requiring the whole booklet at once. Read Indigenous-authored texts for the Indigenous voices theme; identify the specific Nation or community when the book provides it.

Flexible timing

One book/theme: allow about 40–60 minutes, or split into two sessions: prepare and read (15–25 minutes), discuss and respond (20–30 minutes), then share (5 minutes). Stations: introduce one book together, then revisit selected stations over several sessions. Allow enough time to read or listen before responding; a timed rotation is optional. Complete the final reflection after students have encountered at least two books. Children's Day on November 20 offers a connection to rights, belonging and voice, not a deadline to finish every station.

Before the read-aloud

Introduce the author, illustrator and theme. Ask: What do the title and cover make us wonder? What might belonging or fair participation look like here? Invite predictions as possibilities, not facts. Explain that students may discuss the book or another text instead of sharing personal experiences. Agree to listen respectfully, use people's stated names and identities, and question ideas without questioning anyone's dignity.

During the read-aloud

Pause at a few purposeful moments: What do you notice in the words or pictures? What supports your thinking? Whose perspective are we hearing? What questions remain? Revisit a page when interpretations differ. Name unfairness accurately and attend to agency, resistance, care and joy. Do not invent quotations or assume a character speaks for a whole community.

Respond with evidence

Four organizer sections | Book learning comes first

After reading

Revisit the station question and invite a brief partner or whole-class discussion: What did this book help us understand? Which detail changed or deepened our thinking? Model a response using an actual page from the selected book. Distinguish what the text shows from what we infer; explain that several interpretations may be supported by evidence.

1. Main idea or key message

Students state an important message, then use a specific detail from the words or pictures. Prompt: “I think the book helps us understand ___ because ___.” Ask students to point to, describe or reread the evidence. A topic label alone, such as “fairness,” needs explanation.

2. Meaningful illustration

The illustration is required: students draw a scene, picture or symbol that represents the theme in this book and add a short label or caption explaining its meaning. Protect ample drawing space in the organizer; offer a separate sheet if needed. Invite a student to explain how the image connects to a detail in the book. Artistic realism is not the goal. Do not ask students to depict abuse or reenact harm.

3. Why should we learn about this topic?

Students explain what the book helped them understand about people, rights, belonging, relationships or participation. Prompt: “This matters because the book shows ___.” Ask for a link to the text rather than a generic statement that everyone should be kind.

4. Make a connection

Students connect the book to another book, the world or their own life by choice. Prompt: “This reminds me of ___; the connection helps me understand ___.” A text-to-text or teacher-provided real-world connection is always valid. Never require disclosure about identity, family, discrimination, disability, trauma or migration.

Space, access and enrichment

Use page 8 whenever a response needs more room; record the book/topic and question being continued. Accept oral explanation, a scribe, speech-to-text, drawing with labels, home-language responses or supported communication. Preserve the thinking goal while adapting output and pacing. Students may finish the themed colouring frame as secondary enrichment after developing their book response; colouring is not evidence of understanding and should not crowd out reading, discussion or the meaningful illustration.

Connect learning and plan next steps

Six themes | Reflection | Formative assessment

Choose a theme, keep the book central

Indigenous voices: First Nations, Métis and Inuit rights and teachings; honour distinct voices and avoid generalizations. Our shared Earth: sustainability, access to nature and a shared future. Gender, identity and families: explicitly include LGBTQ2S+ voices, sexual orientation, gender identity, diverse families and equal rights. Languages, cultures and communities: include diverse Canadians, languages, traditions and everyday community life, not only immigration. Racism, discrimination and change: examine unfair systems, resistance and change without reenacting oppression or depicting abuse. Accessibility, inclusion and equality: consider visible and non-visible disabilities, barriers and changes supporting full participation; do not simulate disabilities.

Final cross-book reflection • page 7

After at least two books, ask students to name the books they are connecting. Use the booklet's UN Secretary-General prompt: which issue would they focus on, and why? Students connect their choice to at least two books, explain how the books deepened or changed their thinking, and use a real-world example they have learned about to explain a global impact. Provide a verified, age-appropriate example if needed; do not ask students to invent one. Explain that the Secretary-General is a leader who can encourage international cooperation; students are proposing priorities, not claiming one person can solve every issue.

Actions and a message

Students suggest actions for people or governments and explain how these would protect rights. They draw a picture or symbol showing their most important learning and add a caption. Invite specific, feasible ideas and acknowledge the responsibilities of adults and institutions. Use the continuation page as needed. Share by choice, then identify a question to revisit or one class action adults can support.

Formative look-fors

Listen and look for a clear message supported by a relevant detail; an explanation of why the topic matters; a connection that deepens understanding; and an illustration whose meaning the student can explain. In the final reflection, notice links across at least two books, a grounded real-world example and a reasoned rights-protecting action. Use questions and feedback to guide revision rather than an invented scoring rubric. Separate drawing fluency, handwriting and amount of colouring from the student's understanding.

Responsive teaching

If evidence is thin, reread a short passage or image together. If a connection is broad, ask what is similar or different and why that matters. Correct stereotypes calmly and return to accurate language and the specific text. Offer a pause, alternative text or private check-in when needed without requesting an explanation. Optional collaboration with Laura can support book selection or discussion; arrange it separately without assuming a schedule.